

The Ultimate Witness

Acts 6:1-7:60

HOOK: "The Problem of Success"

Former Lee University President, Paul Conn lived in Atlanta several years ago. He noticed a listing in the Yellow Pages (For those of you under 20, they were in this thing called a phone book. It was like a printed out contact list, but it had everyone's number in it. Do you know why they were called the Yellow Pages? You guessed it. Because the pages were yello) for a restaurant called Church of God Grill. Curiosity got the better of him, so he dialed the number.

Here's how Dr. Conn recalls the phone conversation: A man answered saying, "Hello! Church of God Grill!" Dr. Conn asked how the restaurant got such an unusual name. The man explained: "Well, we had a little mission down here. We started selling chicken dinners after church on Sunday to help pay the bills. People loved the chicken. We did such good business that we eventually cut back on the church service. After a while we closed down the church altogether. We kept serving the chicken dinners. We kept the name we started with, and that's Church of God Grill."

That story sounds like a joke, but it isn't. It perfectly illustrates the subtle danger the early church faced. They had a core mission. But a practical need—their own "chicken dinner" problem—became wildly successful. It became so demanding that it threatened to derail everything.

The early church exploded with growth. Thousands came to salvation. The needs overwhelmed them. Right in the middle of this incredible success, they hit their first major crisis. They faced this crisis not because they were failing, but because they were succeeding beyond their wildest dreams.

BOOK: The Text Speaks

Part 1: When Growth Creates Problems (Acts 6:1-7)

Luke begins with these words: "In those days when the number of disciples was increasing..." Notice this—success created the problem.

The issue wasn't theological at first. It was practical, cultural, and deeply human. The Greek-speaking Jewish Christians complained that the daily food distribution neglected their widows. Meanwhile, the Aramaic-speaking Jewish Christians seemed to receive better treatment.

"Now, before we move on, we have to understand who these Hellenistic widows were and why this was such a literal lifeline for them.

- **They were vulnerable outsiders.** These were Greek-speaking Jewish women, immigrants from other parts of the Roman Empire. Many had moved to Jerusalem in their old age, perhaps to spend their golden years in the Holy Land, and they lacked the local family support structure that was essential for survival.
- **Jewish culture demanded their care.** In Jewish tradition, caring for widows and orphans wasn't just charity; it was *tzedakah*—it was justice. It was a core religious duty. The community had systems like a "community chest" or a "daily distribution" of food, a practice the early church honorably continued.
- **There was no safety net.** The Roman government was not providing social security. If you were a widow without a family, you were destitute. So, when these women joined the Christian community, they likely lost any support they might have received from the Temple. The church's daily food distribution wasn't a nice bonus; it was their only meal.

- **This was an internal church problem.** The issue wasn't that the apostles were mean-spirited. The problem was that a cultural and linguistic divide had emerged within the church itself. The leaders were local, Aramaic-speaking Jews, and the Greek-speaking widows were being unintentionally overlooked. The Greek word Luke uses here suggests this wasn't a one-time accident, but a systemic blind spot.

The church was like a new, fast-growing city. When traffic suddenly overwhelms the roads, you don't just yell at the drivers; you have to build new bridges and new lanes to handle the capacity. The apostles had to build a new bridge for ministry to ensure no one was left behind."

This wasn't just about food. This was about justice, dignity, and a crucial question:

Could the gospel really unite people across cultural lines?

The Greek speakers were immigrants—Diaspora Jews who had returned to Jerusalem. Many were elderly widows without local family support. They spoke a different language and followed different customs. Now they felt like second-class citizens in God's new community.

The apostles faced three possible responses:

1. **Option One: Ignore it** - "We're too busy with spiritual things"
2. **Option Two: Micromanage it** - Try to handle everything themselves
3. **Option Three: Delegate wisely** - Find the right people and empower them

They chose option three. This choice changed everything.

Listen to their wisdom: ***"It would not be right for us to neglect the ministry of the word of God in order to wait on tables."***

Notice they didn't say serving tables was beneath them. They used the same Greek word—*diakonia* (ministry)—for both word ministry AND table ministry. Both are sacred service. Both matter to God. But different people receive calls to different functions. Their solution was brilliant: "Choose seven men from among you who are known to be full of the Spirit and wisdom."

Look at those qualifications. They didn't say "choose seven guys who are good with spreadsheets." They didn't say "find some business-minded volunteers." No—choose men full of the Holy Spirit and wisdom. Even the most practical ministry requires spiritual depth.

They needed men full of the Spirit and wisdom. Why? Because ministry isn't just a task; it's a testimony. Think about our church today:

- The person greeting you at the door isn't just a human directional; they are the first handshake of the gospel. It takes the Spirit's love to welcome a stranger who is hurting.
- Isaac, back there in the sound booth isn't just a technician; he is stewarding the atmosphere of worship. It takes the Spirit's wisdom to deflect praise when things go right and to handle pressure when things go wrong.
- The person holding a baby in the nursery isn't just a babysitter; they are ministering peace to a family, allowing a young mother or father to receive the Word of God without distraction. That is a deeply spiritual service.
- The team that counts the offering isn't just handling money; they are guarding the integrity and faithfulness of God's people. That requires a Spirit of wisdom and discretion.

There is no 'just' in the kingdom of God. Every act of service, when done for His glory, requires His Spirit."

Notice something beautiful here. All seven chosen men had Greek names. The apostles essentially told the Greek-speaking community: "You choose your own leaders. We trust you. We won't impose Hebrew leadership on a Greek problem."

What was the result? "So the word of God spread. The number of disciples in Jerusalem increased rapidly, and a large number of priests became obedient to the faith."

Here's the principle: When the church solves its internal problems with spiritual wisdom, it unleashes fresh power for mission.

What does that look like?

- It looks like the baptismal waters getting stirred every single month.
- It looks like small groups multiplying because new leaders are empowered to lead.
- It looks like conversations about Jesus breaking out in offices and breakrooms on Monday.
- It looks like outreach needs not just being met, but overflowing with generosity.
- It looks like former enemies sitting next to each other in the pews, reconciled by the gospel.
- It looks like the community outside our walls seeing us not for our conflicts, but for our love in action!

Part 2: When Faithfulness Provokes Opposition (Acts 6:8-15)

Stephen wasn't content to just organize food distribution. Luke tells us he was "full of God's grace and power." He "performed great wonders and signs among the people."

This is crucial: Faithful service in small things led to powerful ministry in great things.

Stephen started waiting tables. He ended up working miracles.

But success brought opposition. He began debating in the synagogues. "They could not stand up against the wisdom and the Spirit by which he spoke."

When you can't win the argument, what do you do? You attack the person. They brought false charges: ***"This fellow never stops speaking against this holy place and against the law."***

Sound familiar? These were almost the exact charges they brought against Jesus.

When the religious establishment can't defeat your message, they try to destroy your character.

But here's the beautiful detail Luke gives us: "All who were sitting in the Sanhedrin looked intently at Stephen, and they saw that his face was like the face of an angel."

The judges are judging, but God is testifying. Stephen's face shines with divine glory, like Moses coming down from Mount Sinai. The accused is the one radiating God's presence.

Part 3: When Truth Confronts Tradition (Acts 7:1-53)

Stephen's defense speech is the longest sermon in the entire book of Acts. It's a masterpiece of biblical preaching. It recounts Israel's history and builds to a devastating conclusion.

His strategy is brilliant. He doesn't directly defend himself. Instead, he tells their own story back to them. In doing so, he reveals a consistent pattern:

First Pattern: God is not confined to sacred places:

- He appeared to Abraham in Mesopotamia, not the Promised Land
- He was with Joseph in pagan Egypt

- He revealed himself to Moses in the wilderness of Midian
- For forty years, Israel worshiped God in a moveable tent, not a fixed temple

Second Pattern: Israel consistently rejects God's chosen deliverers:

- The patriarchs sold Joseph into slavery—the very one God sent to save them
- The Israelites rejected Moses twice—in Egypt and at Sinai
- They refused the deliverer and turned their hearts back to Egypt

Stephen builds to his climax. When he gets there, he doesn't hold back:

"You stiff-necked people! Your hearts and ears are still uncircumcised. You are just like your ancestors: You always resist the Holy Spirit! Was there ever a prophet your ancestors did not persecute? They even killed those who predicted the coming of the Righteous One. And now you have betrayed and murdered him."

Codex drop moment. This isn't political correctness. This is prophetic confrontation.

Stephen declares: "You think I'm blaspheming Moses and the Temple? You're the ones following the exact pattern of everyone who ever rejected God's messengers!"

Part 4: When Witness Becomes Martyrdom (Acts 7:54-60)

Their reaction was pure fury. Luke says they were "furious and gnashed their teeth at him."

But Stephen, "full of the Holy Spirit, looked up to heaven and saw the glory of God, and Jesus standing at the right hand of God."

Wait—Jesus is standing? Everywhere else in Scripture, the risen Christ sits at God's right hand. This signifies his completed work. But here he's standing. Why?

I believe Jesus stands to welcome home his first martyr. The King rises from his throne to receive his faithful servant.

Stephen's vision becomes his final testimony: "Look, I see heaven open and the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God."

That's when they lost it completely. They rushed him, dragged him outside the city, and began to stone him.

In this dark moment, Luke introduces us to a young man named Saul. He watched the coats of the witnesses as they picked up stones.

But watch Stephen's final moments. Like his Master, he prays two prayers:

First prayer: "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit"—Trust

Second prayer: "Lord, do not hold this sin against them"—Forgiveness

The first martyr dies like his Master lived—with radical grace toward his enemies.

Then Luke adds a simple but profound detail: "When he had said this, he fell asleep."

For the believer, death is not destruction—it's rest. Stephen doesn't "die"—he "falls asleep" in Jesus.

LOOK: What Does This Mean for Us?

Growth Problems are Good Problems

Church, if we're growing, we will have growing pains. Success creates new and complex challenges. For years, right here in Alabama, we watched the success of Nick Saban's football dynasty. From the outside, it just looked like championships and glory. But that success created its own problems. Every athletic director in the country wanted to hire a Saban disciple, so he was constantly losing his best assistant coaches. The success created unreal expectations and a sense of entitlement among the fans. A loss felt like the end of the world. Success itself became a high-pressure environment that was incredibly difficult to manage.

Our church's growth problems are good problems to have! When you can't find a parking spot, praise God! When the children's ministry is bursting at the seams, rejoice! These aren't failures to complain about; they are opportunities to innovate with the Spirit's guidance.

TOOK: What Do We Do Now?

1. Embrace Your Growing Pains

If you're facing challenges because of growth—in your business, your family, your ministry—don't just complain about them. Ask God for wisdom to solve them in ways that advance His kingdom.

2. Seek the Spirit for Every Assignment

Whether God has called you to teach, serve, lead, or simply show up—do it full of the Holy Spirit. Ask Him to fill you with wisdom for your current responsibilities, no matter how small they seem.

3. Be Faithful in Your Current Assignment

You might be waiting for God to give you something "bigger" or "more important." Stop waiting. Be faithful where you are. Stephen didn't campaign for a miracle ministry—it grew out of his faithful service.

4. Prepare for Opposition

If you're living a powerful Christian life, some people won't like it. They might question your motives, attack your character, or try to silence your witness. When opposition comes, remember—you're in good company.

5. Check Your Sacred Cows

Ask the Holy Spirit to show you if you've turned any methods, traditions, or preferences into idols. Are there ways God wants to expand your understanding of how He works?

6. Live and Die Like Jesus

This is the ultimate challenge. Can people see Jesus in how you respond to criticism? In how you treat your enemies? In how you face suffering?

CONCLUSION: The Seed of the Church

The ancient writer Tertullian said, "The blood of the martyrs is the seed of the church." Stephen's death wasn't the end of the story—it was the beginning of the next chapter. His martyrdom sparked a persecution that scattered the believers throughout Judea and Samaria. This fulfilled exactly what Jesus commanded in Acts 1:8.

And that young man, Saul, standing there, giving his approval, holding the coats of the men who were murdering God's servant? Stephen's final prayer was, 'Lord, do not hold this sin against them.' And God answered that prayer beyond what anyone could imagine.

Before Saul would ever write, '***I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me***'; before he would declare, '***To live is Christ and to die is gain***'; before he would boast, '***I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith***'—before any of that, the man he was helping to murder was praying for his forgiveness. The prayer of the first martyr led to the conversion of the greatest apostle.

God has a way of turning our biggest problems into our greatest opportunities. He transforms our deepest defeats into our most decisive victories.

Years ago, in a Welsh village, a small church was trying to raise money to repair its roof. They held a small auction. An old, worn-out violin came up for bid. The auctioneer asked for an opening bid of one pound. No one moved. He asked again. Silence. It seemed worthless.

Just then, an elderly, white-haired man walked up from the back of the room. He picked up the old violin, dusted it off gently, tightened the strings, and tucked it under his chin. Then, he began to play. The most beautiful, soaring melody filled the little chapel, holding everyone breathless. When he finished, the auctioneer, with tears in his eyes, started the bidding again. This time, the violin sold for a thousand pounds.

The auctioneer looked at the crowd and said, 'What made the difference? It was the touch of the master's hand.'

That is the story of the early church, and it is our story. A problem that looked worthless, the Master touched it and turned it into a new ministry. A man who looked like a failure, dying under a pile of rocks, the Master touched him and his death planted the seed for the gospel to go to the nations. A persecutor who looked like an enemy, the Master touched him, and he became an apostle."

Altar Call

So the question today is not, '*What are your problems?*' The question is, '*Will you let the Master touch them?*' What is He making out of you? With every head bowed and every eye closed, I want to give you a chance to respond to that touch.

1. **Maybe you're here and you've never known the touch of the Master's hand in your life.** You feel like that worthless violin, broken and cast aside. Jesus Christ died for you, and He rose again to give you a new song. If you want to

surrender your life to him, to be forgiven and made new, right where you are, just raise your hand.

2. **Maybe you're here this morning and you feel like one of those**

Greek-speaking widows. You're not on the outside looking in; you're on the inside feeling out. You come, you worship, but you feel invisible. You feel overlooked, like your needs don't matter and your name isn't known. Can I tell you, God sees you. He knows your heart, He knows your loneliness, and He brought you to this family to be seen and known. If you're here today and you feel invisible, and you want to pray for God to connect you to His people in a real and life-giving way, would you just slip up your hand?

3. **Perhaps you're a believer, but you've been complaining about your**

'growing pains.' You see the problems but not the potential. You need to ask God for the spiritual wisdom to see your challenge as a divine opportunity. If you're ready to embrace your assignment and trust God with the outcome, would you just raise your hand?

4. **Maybe you've been running from your 'table ministry.'** You feel called to serve in a practical way—in the nursery, with the youth, on the hospitality team—but you've thought it was too small or unimportant. Tonight, you need to answer that call and say, 'I will be faithful in the small things.' If that's you, raise your hand.

5. **Finally, maybe you're like Stephen.** You're being faithful, and it's bringing opposition. You feel the heat, the criticism, the attack on your character. You need the Master's touch to give you grace to stand firm and to love your enemies. If you need that divine strength tonight, would you raise your hand?

Father, for every hand raised, for every heart that is responding, I pray that you would meet them right now with the power of your Holy Spirit. Touch them, change them, and use them for your glory. Amen